

# THE SYSTEM AGAINST THE INDIVIDUAL

*An overall reading of the contradictions of the contemporary world*

## **In brief**

- The system produces a great deal, but does not turn that wealth proportionately into security, time and capacity for choice for people.
- The individual is asked to take responsibility for results that depend on conditions they do not control.
- Those who decide, those who benefit and those who pay are more and more often different people.
- The present is financed by transferring costs onto the future.
- This is why correcting the effects is not enough: the conditions that produce them must be changed.

The contemporary world can be described through data on growth, productivity, debt, poverty, resources and climate. But a person does not experience GDP: a person experiences the possibility of working, having a home, receiving care, studying, having relationships, having time and imagining a future. The central question therefore becomes the relationship between what the system produces and what it concretely allows people to live. The problem of the present is not necessarily that the system produces too little. It could be, on the contrary, that it produces enormously without proportionately transforming this wealth into security, freedom, time and capacity to choose. The crisis of capitalism can then be read as a progressive loss of coherence between production, distribution, power, responsibility and legitimacy.

From the individual's point of view, the economy is a concrete chain: time, work, income, home, consumption, savings, health, relationships, security, future. It is through this chain that the great phenomena are perceived: growth becomes the cost of housing, monetary policy the cost of credit, demographic transformation caring for one's parents or the difficulty of having children, climate change the cost of food. This is why a society can be richer overall and leave many individuals with a growing difficulty in building autonomy: aggregate growth does not guarantee a proportional growth in individual possibilities.

Modern capitalism has built part of its legitimacy around an implicit promise: those who work, educate themselves, save and take on responsibility should be able to

improve their condition progressively. When the relationship between effort and result becomes less and less predictable, a fracture opens between what is asked of the individual and what the system gives back. It is the first contradiction: one can be responsible for one's own choices without really being master of the conditions within which those choices produce their effects.

Productivity can increase enormously without its benefit being automatically transformed into greater security or freedom. The same increase can become wages, profit, investment, lower prices, public service, shorter working hours or greater accumulation: there is no automatic distribution of technological progress. The question is therefore not whether technology is good or bad. It is who controls the benefit it produces and in what form that benefit returns to society.

Capital continually seeks greater productivity, and technology makes it possible to produce more with less labour. But labour is also an essential component of the income that sustains demand. When a growing share of the value produced separates from the income distributed to labour, demand has to be sustained by other means: public spending, exports, redistribution, credit or financial expansion. Some of them may work, but they may also simply shift the problem forward in time.

The home makes the contradiction evident. It is at once a fundamental need, an asset, an investment and financial collateral: for those who own capital it can represent security and wealth, for those who lack it, it can become a barrier to entry into stability. The system can ask the individual for greater efficiency while making the individual's autonomy ever more dependent on variables the individual does not control.

Inequality does not concern only the quantity of goods owned. Wealth allows one to wait, take risks, withstand crises, protect oneself and choose. Economic differences are not automatically unjust: they become more problematic when they turn into differences in the capacity to determine the future. The difference is not only how much you own. It is how much you can afford to decide, and how far you can modify the conditions within which others, too, have to live.

Democracy formally grants citizens a political voice; the market, by contrast, distributes economic capacity according to property, income and capital. The two logics can coexist, but they come into tension when people perceive that they have little capacity to influence the decisions that concern their own lives. The decisive problem then emerges: who decides, who benefits, who pays and who can correct the decision? When these four positions grow too far apart, economic inequality also becomes a question of legitimacy.

An economic decision can produce an immediate benefit and costs distributed over time or space: a firm can gain efficiency while a territory faces changes in employment, an investment can produce a return while others bear environmental costs. The point is not to assign individual blame automatically, but to recognise a structural problem: when the capacity to decide grows faster than the responsibility towards those who will suffer the consequences, the system produces an asymmetry of power. This is perhaps the deepest form of systemic injustice: living inside decisions that one did not help to make and that one does not have the capacity to correct.

The individual is asked to get an education, keep up to date, be competitive, save, be flexible and prepare for change. But the individual does not determine housing prices, interest rates, the labour market, the cost of energy or technological evolution. The consequences are individualised while many of the causes are systemic. This does not eliminate personal responsibility. It does, however, impose a condition of justice: responsibility should be proportionate to the effective capacity to influence the causes.

Millions of rational decisions can produce a result that no one chose. A person may decide to have fewer children because the cost of living is too high: it is an understandable choice. But if many people make the same choice, the population ages, the pressure on care and pension systems increases, and the next generation may find itself in even more difficult conditions. The same holds for the firm that cuts costs because it has to compete, for the worker who accepts worse conditions because they have to keep their income, for the consumer who seeks the lowest price. A system can transform individual rationality into collective irrationality. The problem is not only to correct people's behaviour: it is to build institutions capable of coordinating individual interests towards collectively sustainable results.

Debt makes it possible to bring forward future economic capacity. It is not negative in itself: it can finance investment, infrastructure and productive activities. It becomes problematic when a growing share of future income has to be used to sustain obligations already created, and the system depends more and more on its own future capacity to produce growth. Debt thus becomes not only a financial instrument, but a relationship with the future.

Modern growth has been sustained by industrialisation, population increase, energy consumption, new markets and the exploitation of resources. Today many of these margins are harder to widen: the population is ageing, infrastructure has to be maintained, the climate generates new costs and material resources remain finite. The fundamental question changes: not how much we can produce, but how much we can produce without consuming the conditions of future production.

An economy does not use financial capital alone. It also uses natural resources, health, time, infrastructure, trust, human capital and social capital. If it consumes them faster than it manages to replenish them, it can increase production in the short term while reducing its own future capacity: environmental degradation uses future ecological capacity, precarisation consumes human capital, low cohesion consumes social capital. The present can be financed by transferring costs onto the future. And the question becomes: who benefits today and who bears the cost tomorrow?

A system can be unequal, inefficient and even produce crises without immediately losing legitimacy. The fracture grows deeper when the conviction spreads that the ordinary instruments are no longer sufficient to correct it. If the individual thinks "I can study, work, save and behave responsibly, but the fundamental conditions of my life are decided elsewhere", the question is no longer only economic. It becomes institutional.

At this point it is not enough to ask how much the system produces. One must ask how it distributes what it produces, how much control the individual really has over their own life, how legitimate it is to transfer costs to future generations, and why the increase in productivity should necessarily translate into greater production and not also into more human time. Data can describe these conditions; they cannot establish by themselves what is just. My interpretation is that a system becomes progressively fragile when it demands responsibility from individuals without guaranteeing them a proportionate capacity to influence the fundamental conditions of their own existence.

If these contradictions were only occasional errors, it would be sufficient to correct them. But if they derive from the very way in which property, labour, production and power are organised, redistribution alone cannot be the definitive answer: income can be redistributed without changing the ownership of the means of production, workers can be protected while labour is kept as a commodity, pollution can be taxed without changing the criterion that makes it profitable to produce. Redistribution acts on the result; systemic change must act on the conditions that produce it. It means production that starts from real need and not from price, necessary labour that becomes contribution, fundamental goods held in common custody, a market that remains an instrument, power that is a temporary function and not a position, technology that helps to decide but does not decide, progress measured by sufficiency. And it starts from the individual: no one must be deprived of necessary goods because they do not own enough.

The conclusion to which this analysis leads is that capitalism must no longer be the dominant principle of social organisation. Not simply because it is considered morally unsatisfactory, but because it is no longer capable of reconciling production, freedom, justice, sustainability and responsibility. Capitalism must end. But this sentence

acquires meaning only if one understands what comes after: if the fundamental structures remain the same, the problem may simply reappear in another form.

There does not exist today a complete, verified and universally applicable alternative system. There are partial experiences, from cooperatives to commons, from universal services to open technologies, but none of them constitutes on its own a complete answer. This is why the alternative must be built, and it is here that the Constitution of the Circles takes on its meaning: not as a perfect model nor as a dogma, but as the first concrete architecture of an alternative that does not yet fully exist. It is a matter of building a system in which individual and collectivity cease to be opposed because the freedom of the one becomes materially possible through the responsibility of the other.

The alternative cannot be considered finished even once it has been written. It will have to be tested, it will have to fail at certain points, it will have to be corrected, because the greatest risk would be to replace a system that claims to be inevitable with another that claims to be perfect. We do not yet know what the society to come will be in its definitive form. But we do know which contradictions we can no longer ignore.

The end of capitalism is not the point of arrival. It is the point at which the hardest work begins. We are not obliged to regard the system we have inherited as inevitable. But if we want to go beyond it, we cannot limit ourselves to rejecting it. We must become capable of building another way of living.